

Launchpad

An application launcher can be thought of as a 'shell' for the OS. Most of us have seen the shell replacements that can be done on a Windows OS—the appearance as well as the user interface of the OS can be changed using these shell replacements. An application launcher for PDAs does the same thing.

A common feature available in most application launchers is the ability to change your Palm theme. Most launchers offer additional downloadable themes. In addition to this, some allow icon sets to be downloaded so that you can choose the icon to be used for each application. This is a neat feature since most themes do not allow selective changing of icons.

Drag-and-drop of applications—something the Palm does not offer as a standard feature—is available in almost all application launchers. This feature lets you simply drag-and-drop applications for beaming, deleting, information, and so on. Yet another very useful feature is the file manager type of utility, which helps you manage applications as you would on an OS such as Windows.

In addition to these basic tools, application launchers have their own custom features such as automatic access to frequently accessed or bookmarked applications, shortcuts or buttons that can be configured to run the applications you set it for and so on. SilverScreen, HandScape, GoBar, MegaL and PAL are some popular application launchers available for the Palm.

Themes from the SilverScreen

Well, it's a bit of a drag to see the same old look everyday, isn't it? So, before familiarity rouses contempt, spice up your relationship with new themes.

Themes provide you with ways to replace the application icons of the Palm with grey-scale graphics of your choice. There are several themes available from the Pocketsensei site (www.pocketsensei.com) for free.

Setting up your own theme is pretty simple. First of all, download the theme you want into your PC. The file will be compressed—usually a

.zip file for the PC and a .sit file for the Mac. Unzip the file and extract it into a folder in your PC. Get hold of the .pdb file and simply install it in your Palm using Palm Desktop. SilverScreen will automatically recognise all the installed themes.

Go to Options and select Theme. Now the Theme box comes up as shown in the picture. Select from the list the theme you want displayed, tap on OK and there you go. Your Palm has a new look altogether.

If you belong to the elite clan of those who

own a colour Palm, you are going to enjoy themes the most. Remember that colour themes for colour PDAs require that you install Chromacast from the Pocketsensei site. Of course, we don't mean to say that people without colour Palms won't enjoy it. The limitation here is that you will have lesser options when it comes to extracting the full potential of the themes. Not all the themes that you can get hold of may run on a monochrome Palm.



Select the theme from the theme box



Your new look Palm

icon at the top-right shows recently accessed applications.

The most attractive features are the pair of buttons on the tool bar called Hot Spots, which can be configured to perform the job you want it to do through the shortest route possible. Configuring Hot Spots is easy. You can either tap on it when configuring for the first time or use SilverScreen Prefs in the Options menu.

Select the options you want to give the Hot Spots from the drop-down menu. There is a Ticker feature as well, which you can enable using the Ticker choice in the Options drop-down menu. SilverScreen offers a lot of features, but it has some drawbacks when it comes to usability. The learning curve involved in order to master all the



Configuring SilverScreen preferences

applications is quite steep. Besides, the very fact that SilverScreen has so many features makes it a little difficult to manage, especially if you need only the basic features of an application launcher. But if you would like to try it out anyway, you can obtain a trial version at www.pocketsensei.com.

A HandScape for your Palm

HandScape is an application launcher which consists of a Live Desktop and a file manager. Install it and make it the default launcher during the easy installation process. The HandScape interface looks similar to SilverScreen with its tabs and the Toolbox for dragging and dropping applications. But if you are looking forward to making some cosmetic changes to your PDA, forget it. Unlike SilverScreen, HandScape does not have themes or replaceable icons.

Clicking on the icon at the top-right corner lets you switch between the ordinary icon kind of interface and a 'Windows Explorer' kind of file manager. A neat feature here is the context menu, which allows you to create new folders and attach notes to specific folders. You can rename and delete folders just as you are used to doing while using a PC. Using the context menu is pretty simple too. Just hold down the stylus on